Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced an important initiative at the Glasgow Climate summit in 2021, entitled LiFE or Lifestyle for the Environment. This seeks to mobilise a worldwide movement for the adoption of a lifestyle that preserves the ecological integrity of our planet. It acknowledges that at the heart of the current ecological crisis is the value system underlying our current lifestyles. Unless this value system is transformed, there is no likelihood of reversing the ecological crisis. The prime minister's initiative must be incorporated in India's own economic growth strategy to be credible and to be an example to other countries. India needs to articulate a "vision of a new path of development", in the words of Nicholas Stern. This new path remains be spelt out.

The BJP-led government often harks back to India's ancient glories, its civilisational brilliance and ageless wisdom. Indian culture treats Nature as a mother, a source of nurture and of beauty in all its myriad manifestations. This is the opposite of the driver of modern industrial civilisation, which regards Nature as a dark force to be harnessed and conquered to serve humanity. It is this attitude of mind that has led to the ravaging of our planet, the destruction of vast expanses of forests, the pollution of our rivers and oceans and the continuing extinction of many of the planet's diverse living species. Just 4 per cent of the living mammals on the planet are wild animals; 60 per cent are domesticated livestock, such as cattle, pigs and sheep and 36 per cent are humans. Domesticated livestock are bred on an industrial scale in congested spaces, leading to outbreaks of disease that must be controlled through large-scale use of antibiotics and other toxic drugs. These then find their way into the food chain, causing mounting health problems. We are trapped in a vicious circle, which is inherent in our production and consumption systems. Climate change is only one dimension of the ecological crisis and will not be solved only through the reduction of carbon emissions emanating from fossil fuel use.

India, too, is trapped in this vicious circle. It cannot bring about a change overnight, but it can reorient its development towards an ecologically more sustainable path by formulating a long-term strategy with clear intermediate milestones. The Long-Term Strategy to achieve India's target of Net Zero of carbon emissions by 2070, which India submitted at COP-27, is a disappointment in this respect.

What are some things India could do to translate LiFE into practical action?

In a democracy like India, all citizens are entitled to the right to mobility. This is different from the entitlement to owning and running a vehicle. The current density of vehicle penetration in India is 32 per 1,000, while it is 800 per 1,000 in Europe and 900 in the US. If India aspired to even a fraction of this vehicle density, not all the oil in the world would be sufficient. Even if it were, there would simply be neither room to park the cars nor enough roads and highways to run them on. Electric cars are not an answer since power to run them must come from some energy source, even if it is not fossil fuels. The sustainable provision of mobility would seek to promote efficient and affordable public transportation while discouraging private car ownership through higher taxation. The large sums of money being spent on constructing six-lane highways and urban flyovers would instead be used to develop efficient rail and river transport. India needs a completely revamped transportation strategy. This must be an integral component of the LiFE initiative.

A SUSTAINABLE PROVISION OF MOBILITY COULD SEEK **TO PROMOTE EFFICIENT AND AFFORDABLE PUBLIC TRANSPORTATION** WHILE DISCOURAGING PRIVATE CAR OWNERSHIP

India is still predominantly an agricultural country—agriculture provides livelihood for 58 per cent of its 1.4 billion population. The country is still locked into a strategy of intensive agricultural development programme (IADP), which harks back to the Green Revolution of the 1960s. Successful at the time, it has been yielding diminishing returns for several decades now. The Green Revolution involved the use of hybrid wheat and rice seeds, coupled with intensive use of chemical fertilisers and water to assure high yields.